

AN ASPIRATIONAL BUDGET

FINANCE MINISTER NIRMALA SITHARAMAN TALKS ABOUT
SOCIAL SECTOR SPENDING, CAPEX, THE NEW TAX REGIME
AND WHY THIS YEAR'S BUDGET ISN'T A POPULIST ONE

PHOTOS BY **HARDIK CHHABRA**

REFUTING SUGGESTIONS THAT the Budget 2023-24 proposals were populist in nature, Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman tells a panel of *Business Today* and Aaj Tak Editors that the Budget is, in fact, rather forward-looking. Taking questions on a wide range of issues from social sector spending to revision in income tax rates to the Adani-Hindenburg saga, Sitharaman says that the next 25 years of *Amrit Kaal* would be all about

addressing India's collective aspirations. Edited excerpts:



Rahul Kanwal: *What is your reaction to the Opposition's remarks on the reduction in allocation for social sector schemes?*

I invite them to go and look into the details of the Budget. When it comes to the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment

